POCKET GUIDE

for GBV actors working with male survivors of sexual violence



Gender-Based Violence AoR
Гуманітарна координація у сфері
гендерно зумовленого насильства

Gender-Based Violence AoR
Ukraine

PURPOSE OF THE DOCUMENT:

This document aims to provide guidance for those working with male survivors of sexual violence. It emphasizes the importance of recognizing and addressing the specific needs of this group, including the barriers they may face in accessing services. The guide also highlights the need for sensitivity and understanding when interacting with male survivors and offers key messages and communication strategies to ensure their experiences are validated and respected.

WHAT IS SEXUAL VIOLENCE AGAINST MALES?

Sexual violence is an umbrella term and can include any of the following acts:

- **Rape or attempted rape.**
- **Unwanted touching.**
- **Being forced to observe or listen to sexual violence.**
- **Coerced or forced participation in sexual activity, including sexual violence against other.**
- **Genital violence, which may include shocks or beating aimed at the testicles and penis, and castration.**
- **Forced stripping.**
- **Forced masturbation and other forms of sexual humiliation.**
- **Sexual exploitation.**
- **Trafficking for the purposes of sexual exploitation**

Sexual violence against males includes conflict related sexual violence as well as sexual violence that is not linked to the conflict. Sexual violence is underreported and the nature and scale of sexual violence against men is difficult to verify. However, it is important to note that women and girls are disproportionately affected by GBV, including sexual violence and conflict related sexual violence. Services and support for male survivors should not undermine GBV services for women and girls.

CONSIDERATIONS FOR PROGRAMMING:

- Services for male survivors should not be provided in women and girls spaces and other female only spaces. Organisations working with male survivors should identify confidential spaces to meet with male survivors in spaces they can access without compromising their confidentiality.

- Male survivors may experience barriers in accessing services located in largely female spaces, such as maternity hospitals, psychosocial support services mainly providing assistance to women and children.

- Protection monitoring shows that some men in Ukraine are engaging in self-imposed restrictions in their movements, including participating in humanitarian activities, due concerns regarding mobilisation. GBV actors can widely disseminate information regarding phone and remote services for male survivors to support their access to services.

- Psychosocial services should be accessible to male survivors of sexual violence, considering the mental health impacts they may face, such as anxiety, depression, self-harm, suicidal thoughts, sleep disorders, anger, PTSD, substance abuse, and risky sexual behaviour. Socially, men and boys may encounter ridicule, blame, and social isolation from family and wider community members. Similar to the impact for female survivors, sexual violence can impact male survivors' relationships, including their sense of trust in relationships. Adult survivors might struggle with job responsibilities, risking job loss and poverty, while boy survivors may leave school and develop behavioural issues or resort to substance abuse.



KEY MESSAGES:

- **MALE SURVIVORS MAY FACE BARRIERS IN ACCESSING IN-PERSON SERVICES** due to concerns regarding stigma, mobilisation and fears of confidentiality.
- **SIMILAR TO FEMALE SURVIVORS, MALE SURVIVORS OF SEXUAL VIOLENCE CAN EXPERIENCE STIGMA, ISOLATION AND DISCONNECT** from family, friends, and communities which may prevent the survivor from reporting and seeking help.
- **RAPE IS RAPE, REGARDLESS OF THE SURVIVOR'S SEX, GENDER IDENTITY—** whether presumed or actual—or sexual orientation, and it always constitutes a violation of international human rights.
- In consensual sexual relationships, a person's actions, self-recognized sexual orientation, or gender identity are typically aligned. **HOWEVER, IN SITUATIONS INVOLVING COERCION, THESE ELEMENTS CAN BECOME DISCONNECTED.** For instance, experiencing forced penetrative sex does not make a man or boy homosexual, nor does it alter a person's gender identity.
- An experience of sexual violence **DOES NOT IMPACT A MALE SURVIVOR'S SEXUAL ORIENTATION.**
- **MOST PERPETRATORS OF SEXUAL VIOLENCE AGAINST MALE SURVIVORS ARE OTHER MALES.**
- **NOT ADDRESSING SEXUAL VIOLENCE AGAINST MEN AND BOYS CAN LEAD SOME SURVIVORS TO USE HARMFUL COPING STRATEGIES**, including, in extreme cases, violence. This can have long-lasting negative effects on their families and the wider community.
- **TIMELY ACCESS TO HEALTH SERVICES IS CRUCIAL FOR MALE SURVIVORS OF SEXUAL VIOLENCE**, as it allows for prompt testing and treatment of HIV and other sexually transmitted infections (STIs), preventing long-term health complications.



IEC MATERIALS:

- **USE GENDER NEUTRAL LANGUAGE** like 'They/them' instead of he/she or him/her.
- **USE 'PERSON OR INDIVIDUAL'** instead of gender-specific terms like 'man' or 'woman'
- Communication materials that only have **INFOGRAPHICS OF FEMALES MAY NOT FEEL INCLUSIVE FOR MALE** survivors as they can send the message the services are only for females.
- **CONSIDER THE COLOUR/DESIGN OF THE LEAFLETS**—leaflets that are pink/purple or other colours traditionally associated with femininity may not be inclusive to male survivors. Gender neutral colours may be more inclusive and accessible for male survivors.
- **IMAGES THAT ARE TRADITIONALLY ASSOCIATED WITH FEMININITY** such as flowers **MAY SIGNAL TO MALE SURVIVORS THAT THE SERVICES ARE NOT ACCESSIBLE FOR THEM.**
- The **PLACEMENT OF IEC MATERIALS SHOULD BE CONSIDERED TO ENSURE THAT THEY CAN BE ACCESSED SAFELY AND CONFIDENTIALLY,** particularly considering that some men are engaging in self-imposed movement restrictions. Social media and online awareness raising should be considered as a way to reach men with information.

DOS AND DON'TS OF RESPONDING TO A DISCLOSURE FROM A MALE SURVIVORS OF SEXUAL VIOLENCE

✓ **DO FOLLOW THE GBV GUIDING PRINCIPLES** (Respect, Confidentiality, Safety, and Non-discrimination)

✓ **DO PROVIDE REASSURANCE AROUND CONFIDENTIALITY.**

✓ **DO USE THE WORDS AND TERMS THAT THE SURVIVOR CHOOSES TO DESCRIBE THEIR EXPERIENCE**, and be careful with sensitive terms like sexual violence, rape, victim, and survivor.

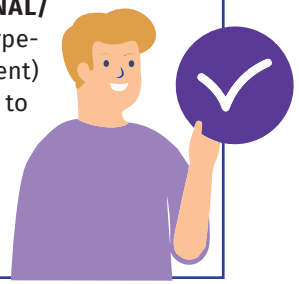
✓ **DO ENSURE THAT MALE SURVIVORS FEEL PHYSICALLY SAFE** and that their service providers emphasise with them.

✓ **DO ENSURE THAT MALE SURVIVORS FEEL FREE FROM JUDGEMENT OR BLAME** and that they can be certain that they can speak confidentially.

✓ **DO GIVE TIME AND MAKE SURE SURVIVORS FEEL ACCEPTED** as whole individuals, not just defined by the label of 'victim' or 'survivor.'

✓ **DO PROVIDE INFORMATION ABOUT URGENT MEDICAL SERVICES**, if appropriate, and all other available services, confidentially and sensitively.

✓ **DO TREAT ANY INFORMATION, INCLUDING PERSONAL/IDENTIFYING INFORMATION** (such as survivor's name, perpetrator(s)' name, date of birth, address, time/place of incident) shared by the survivor with confidentiality. If you need to seek advice and guidance on how to best support a survivor, ask for the survivor's permission to talk to a specialist or colleague. Do so without revealing personal/identifying information and only on a need-to-know basis.

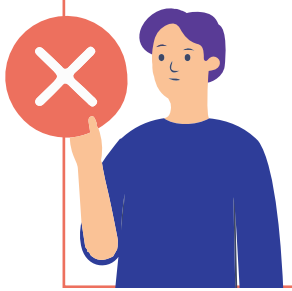


✗ **DO NOT MEET WITH MALE SURVIVORS IN FEMALE ONLY SPACES**, including women and girls' safe spaces.

✗ **DO NOT SET UP SAFE SPACES FOR MALE SURVIVORS** but ensure there are service delivery points for male survivors too

✗ **DO NOT ASSUME THAT A MALE SURVIVOR WANTS TO TALK TO A MALE STAFF MEMBER. EACH MALE SURVIVOR HAS A PERSONAL PREFERENCE FOR THEIR SERVIC**e provider's gender.

✗ **DO NOT ASSUME A CLIENT'S SEXUAL ORIENTATION OR GENDER IDENTITY.**



✗ **DO NOT TRY TO REDEFINE SURVIVOR'S EXPERIENCE.**

✗ **DO NOT MAKE DECISIONS THAT COULD AFFECT SURVIVORS' FUTURES** without their consent or involvement.

✗ **DO NOT USE WORDS OR COMMENTS THAT BLAME THE SURVIVOR OR IMPOSE YOUR OWN FEELINGS**, such as "You're lucky nothing worse happened" or "If I were you."

SUPPORTING SURVIVORS WITH A DIVERSE SOGIESC

When supporting survivors with diverse SOGIESC (sexual orientation, gender identity and expression, and sex characteristics):

- **USE INCLUSIVE LANGUAGE:** Employ gender-neutral terms and avoid making assumptions about a person's identity or experiences.
- **CREATE A SAFE AND AFFIRMING ENVIRONMENT:** Foster a space where individuals feel comfortable expressing their SOGIESC without fear of judgment or discrimination.
- **RESPECT INDIVIDUAL PREFERENCES:** Listen actively to the survivor's needs and preferences, and tailor support services accordingly.
- **ACKNOWLEDGE INTERSECTIONALITY:** Recognize that individuals may face multiple forms of discrimination based on their SOGIESC and address these intersecting identities in a sensitive manner.
- **PROVIDE CULTURALLY COMPETENT CARE:** Understand the cultural and social contexts that shape a person's experiences and adapt support services to meet their specific needs.
- **ENSURE SAFETY OF PERSONAL/IDENTIFYING INFORMATION OF A SURVIVOR:** Do not share the details of the incident and personal identifiers of the survivor with anyone. This includes the survivor's family members, police/security forces, community leaders, colleagues, supervisors, etc. Sharing this information can cause more harm to the survivor.



SOME SPECIFIC WAYS TO USE INCLUSIVE LANGUAGE WHEN WORKING WITH SURVIVORS WITH DIVERSE SOGIESC INCLUDE:

- **USING GENDER-NEUTRAL PRONOUNS AND TERMS:** Instead of assuming someone's pronouns, use gender-neutral terms like "they," "them," "their," or "person" until you know their preferred pronouns.

- **AVOIDING MAKING ASSUMPTIONS ABOUT SOMEONE'S IDENTITY OR EXPERIENCES:** Don't assume someone's sexual orientation, gender identity, or gender expression based on their appearance or name.

- **ASKING OPEN-ENDED QUESTIONS:** Use open-ended questions that enable the survivor to share their experiences and identities in their own words.

- **USING INCLUSIVE LANGUAGE IN ALL COMMUNICATION MATERIALS:** This includes using gender-neutral language in intake forms, brochures, and other materials.

- **BEING MINDFUL OF THE LANGUAGE USED WHEN DISCUSSING RELATIONSHIPS AND FAMILY:** Use inclusive terms like "partner" or "significant other" instead of assuming someone's marital status or family structure.

EXAMPLES OF WHAT TO SAY WHILE WORKING WITH MALE SURVIVORS OF SEXUAL VIOLENCE

- *"How can I support you?"*
- *"Please share with me whatever you want to share. You do not need to tell me about your experience in order for me to provide you with information on the support available to you."*
- *"What happened was not your fault." "I'm sorry this happened to you."*
- *"There are some people/organisations that may be able to provide some support to you and/or your family. Would you like to know about them?"*
- *"Here are the details of the service including the location, times that the service is open, the cost (if applicable), transport options and the person's name for who you can talk to."*
- *"Do not feel pressure to make any decisions now. You can think about things and always change your mind in the future."*

REMEMBER, every survivor's journey is unique. By approaching each individual with sensitivity, respect, and an open mind, service providers can create a truly inclusive and empowering environment for all.

For more information on the work with the male survivors of sexual violence in Ukraine, please reach out to

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